MARIE VEAU — FULL INTRODUCTION

Available: Day 3+ **Location:** Swamp path → Marie's cabin **Trigger:** Player moves toward swamp OR asks about her following HATTIE_MENTIONED_MARIE / HARLAN_WALKED_WITH **Special Trigger:** Asking Marie about the missing package then returning at night → TRUST_MARIE +2

APPROACHING THE SWAMP — Day 3+

The mill road runs out at the edge of town and becomes a footpath, and the footpath becomes suggestion, and the suggestion becomes swamp. The ground goes soft underfoot without warning — one step firm, the next giving slightly, like the earth is breathing.

The willows are thick here. They hang so low their branches trail the water and in the wind they move like something alive and deliberate. The air smells of standing water, green rot, woodsmoke, and something underneath all of it that Marcus cannot name and does not try to.

He has been told not to come here. By everyone who said anything at all about it, the message was the same — leave the swamp alone. Leave the woman alone.

He keeps walking.

The path curves and the cabin appears.

THE CABIN — First Sight

It is old. Older than the town, older than the mill road that sort of leads to it, older than the willows that have grown up around it like a slow embrace. The wood has gone silver-gray with age and the porch has sunk into the earth at one corner and made its peace with that. Bundles of dried things hang from the eaves — herbs, roots, things that might have been animals once, things Marcus cannot identify and his eyes slide away from without quite deciding to.

The door is open.

He did not see it open. It simply is.

The air at the threshold is different. Not colder — *denser.* Like stepping into a room where a conversation just stopped. Something hums at the edge of hearing that has no source. The hairs on Marcus's arms register it before his brain does.

He steps inside.

THE INTERIOR

The cabin is one main room and whatever is behind the curtain at the back that Marcus does not look at directly and cannot explain why.

What he can see:

A fireplace with a fire that burns slightly too low for how warm the room is. Iron pots hanging at different heights. Shelves covering most of two walls — and on the shelves:

Interesting: Jars of things in suspension — roots, stones, dried flowers, seeds in colors that don't quite exist in nature. Bundles of feathers tied with cord in patterns that feel intentional. Candles burned to different heights, some still smoking, arranged in configurations that suggest geometry. Books with no titles on their spines. A mortar and pestle stained so deeply the original color is a memory. Small cloth figures — carefully made, carefully placed, facing specific directions.

Horrifying: A jar of teeth. Not animal teeth — or not only animal teeth. Something in a second jar that moves slightly when Marcus looks at it and is still when he looks away. A set of bones laid out on a cloth in an arrangement that might be a map or might be something else. On the wall above the fireplace, burned directly into the wood — symbols. Old ones. Some of them Marcus has seen before. On the wooden boundary marker in the field where he woke up.

The room smells of smoke and earth and something floral that has no business being this deep in a swamp. It is not an unpleasant smell. That fact alone makes Marcus more uneasy than anything on the shelves.

Then she speaks.

MARIE — First Appearance

"Ferme la porte."

She is behind him. He did not hear her enter. The door closes — he closes it, because the instruction was plain enough — and when he turns she is already sitting in the chair by the fire as though she has been there all along.

She is—

She is difficult to look at directly. Not because she is frightening. Because she is the opposite of frightening in a way that requires attention, and attention in this room feels like a thing with consequences.

Her age is genuinely impossible to determine. Her face holds something ageless and deliberate — like a decision was made about it once and has been kept. Dark skin, dark eyes that catch the firelight and give back more than they receive. She is dressed in layers of dark fabric, practical and particular. Her hair wrapped in cloth the color of deep water.

She looks at Marcus.

Not at his face. *Through* it. The way a person looks at a window they're not interested in — they're looking at what's on the other side.

Marcus is tense. He does not know why he is still standing here. He does not leave.

"Sit down, cher," she says. Her voice is low and unhurried, threaded through with an accent thick as river water — French underneath, something older underneath that. *"You been standing in the cold long enough."*

THE EXCHANGE — Marie's Interview

> *Unlike Harlan's probing — which was investigative — Marie's questions are diagnostic. She already knows what Marcus is. She is determining what kind of man he is underneath it.*

She watches him settle. The fire pops once. Somewhere outside a bird calls and goes quiet.

"You come from that field," she says. Statement. *"Woke up not knowing what you'd done. Clothes all torn."* She tilts her head slightly. *"Smelling like something that don't wash off."*

She picks up something from beside her chair — a small bundle of dried stems — and turns it slowly in her hands without looking at it.

"You not the first," she says. *"Won't be the last. This land — it calls things. Always has. Long before these people build their ugly little town on top of it."*

Her eyes return to Marcus. Through Marcus.

"But you — you interesting."

QUESTION 1 — "What is your name, and where were you going?"

> *She asks this even though she likely knows. She wants to hear how he says it.*

Response	Marie Reads It	Effect
Full name, honest destination	*"Marcus Grave."* Something moves across her face. She says the name back once, quietly, like tasting it. *"A good name for a man carrying what you carry."*	TRUST_MARIE +1
First name, vague destination	She nods slowly. Doesn't push. Files the evasion.	Neutral
Guarded, gives nothing	*"Mmm."* She turns back to the fire. The silence has weight.	TRUST_MARIE -1

QUESTION 2 — "Who was with you on that road?"

> *Her voice doesn't change. Her eyes do — sharpening slightly.*

Response	Marie Reads It	Effect
Tell her about Curtis honestly	She is still for a moment. *"Your friend."* Not a question. *"And now he gone."* She looks at the fire. *"Gone — but not far."*	TRUST_MARIE +1, MARIE_KNOWS_CURTIS set
Say he was alone	Her gaze returns to him. Patient. *"Cher."* Just that. She does not believe him and does not need to say so.	Neutral — she'll return to this
Ask how she knows someone was with him	The corner of her mouth moves. Not quite a smile. *"This swamp see everything that move at night on this land. Everything."*	TRUST_MARIE +1 — honesty about curiosity counts

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QUESTION 3 — "How long you been hurt like this?"

> *She means the hunger. The rage. The thing building underneath his skin.*

Response	Marie Reads It	Effect
Admit it's getting harder to manage	She nods once, slowly. *"Oui. It always does, without help."* She sets the bundle down. *"The hunger — it climb every day, yes? At night it get loud."*	TRUST_MARIE +1, MARIE_HUNGER_ACKNOWLEDGED set
Deny anything is wrong	A long look. *"You lyin' to me or to yourself?"* She doesn't wait for an answer.	TRUST_MARIE -1
Ask what she knows about it	*"More than anyone in that town."* Simply. *"More than the old man walking your field, too."*	TRUST_MARIE +1 — and a flag raises

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THE HARLAN QUESTION — Contributes to CONTAINED Ending

> *She asks this casually. It is not casual.*

"That old man," she says, her eyes on the fire. *"The one walking the field every morning."* She pauses. *"He speak to you?"*

PLAYER CHOICES:

A — "He told me about the town. Pointed me here." She is quiet for a moment. *"Did he."* The two words carry something that isn't surprise. *"And did he say why he don't come in himself?"*

- If Marcus says no: *"No. He wouldn't."* She looks at him now. *"That man is not what he appear to be, cher. You remember that."*
- HARLAN_MARIE_WARNED set. CONTAINED_THREAD +1

B — "He asked me a lot of questions. Felt like an interview." Something in her stillness shifts. *"Questions."* She says it carefully. *"What kind of questions?"* Whatever Marcus describes — she listens without interrupting. When he finishes she turns back to the fire. *"He writing things down in his head, that one. Everything you told him — it go somewhere. You understand?"*

- HARLAN_MARIE_WARNED set. CONTAINED_THREAD +2
- **Highest contribution to CONTAINED ending** — Marcus now knows Harlan reports somewhere. If player pursues this: *"Where does it go?"* Marie looks at him. *"Somewhere that don't have a good history with things like you."*

C — "He seemed like a harmless old man." She makes a sound. Not quite a laugh. *"Mmm."* She picks up the bundle of stems again. *"Harmless."* She turns it in her hands. *"The most dangerous people always do."*

- CONTAINED_THREAD +1 — partial contribution

D — "I don't trust him." She looks at Marcus sharply. Then something settles in her expression — not approval exactly. Recognition. *"Good,"* she says. *"Hold onto that."*

- CONTAINED_THREAD +1, TRUST_MARIE +1 — instinct and honesty together

E — "He didn't say much." / Deflect She nods like this was expected. *"He never do."* She looks at Marcus directly. *"But he listen. Remember that."*

- CONTAINED_THREAD +0 — neutral, no contribution

THE PROPOSAL — Marie's Offer

The fire settles lower. She has been watching Marcus through all of it — through the questions, through the answers, through the silence between them.

She speaks now without preamble.

"You got problems, cher. More than one kind." She holds up a finger. *"You got something in you that's going to eat you alive if you don't learn to carry it right."* A second finger. *"You got a friend out in those woods who ain't your friend no more — but you don't know that yet."* She pauses. The third finger doesn't go up. *"And you got something coming from the outside. A man. Angry."*

She sets her hand down.

"I can help you with two of those things. Maybe all three, if you earn it."

She looks at him steadily.

"What I don't do — I don't do for nothing. And I don't do for people I don't trust."

TRUST ASSESSMENT — Based on TRUST_MARIE Score

> *The score going into this moment determines what Marie offers.*

TRUST_MARIE 4+ — Full Offer

"You can stay here," she says. *"Out of that inn. Out of that town's sight. People won't come looking for you here — they too scared of me."* The corner of her mouth. *"Smart of them."*

"In return — you do what I ask when I ask it. You answer my questions honest. And you don't bring your outside trouble to my door without warning me first."

She extends her hand across the fire. Palm up. An offering and a test simultaneously.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Take her hand or decline]

- **Take it:** MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED set. TRUST_MARIE +2. *Her hand is warm. Warmer than the fire accounts for. When Marcus lets go something sits differently in the room — like a door closed somewhere.* HUMANITY +5 — a human connection, strange as it is, costs nothing to the wolf.
- **Decline — stay at the inn:** She withdraws her hand without offense. *"The offer stand,"* she says. *"When you ready."* MARIE_HOUSING_AVAILABLE set — can be taken later.

TRUST_MARIE 2–3 — Partial Offer

"You not ready to trust me," she says. Not an accusation. *"That's all right. Trust take time."*

She stands. The conversation is ending.

"You come back. We talk more. The offer — it depend on what I see from you."

MARIE_HOUSING_LOCKED — requires two more positive interactions before unlocking.

TRUST_MARIE 0–1 — No Offer

She looks at Marcus for a long moment. Then she stands and moves toward the curtained back room with the unhurried finality of a woman who has made decisions.

"Come back when you ready to be honest," she says, without turning. *"I'll know when that is."*

The door opens behind Marcus. He did not hear it open.

He leaves. The door closes.

THE CABIN AT NIGHT — Special Trigger

> *If Marcus visits Marie after the drugs go missing AND returns at night per her instruction:*

TRUST_MARIE +2 applied before the exchange begins.

The swamp at night is a different country. The willows move without wind. The water reflects a sky too bright for cloud cover. Marcus's eyes adjust faster than they should.

The cabin fire is visible from the path — orange through the willow curtain. She is waiting.

When he steps inside she is already speaking, back turned, stirring something over the fire.

"You came back," she says. *"Bon. That tell me something."*

She turns. In the firelight she is—

The word that comes is *luminous.* Not soft. Not gentle. The dark kind of luminous — the kind that deep water has, or the moon through cloud cover. Something in Marcus responds to it in a way that is not entirely him and not entirely the wolf either. Something in between.

He sits down before he decides to.

"Now," she says. *"Let's talk about what happened on that road."*

SCENE NOTES

- **The symbols on the cabin wall** match the boundary markers in the field. Marie put those markers there — or she knows who did. The land's sacred history runs through her hands directly.
- **"Gone but not far"** about Curtis is the closest anyone gets to telling Marcus the truth this early. Marie knows Curtis is in the pack. She won't say it plainly — not yet. Marcus has to be ready to hear it.
- **The warmth of her hand** during the agreement — that is not incidental. Something passed between them. The game never specifies what. Marie knows.
- **The Harlan question is the most consequential thing in this scene** for the CONTAINED ending. Players who give detailed answers about Harlan's behavior and follow up with questions contribute most. The ending requires this thread plus later Harlan interactions plus DOMINION_THREAD fully active.
- **The back room behind the curtain** — never described in this scene. It is there throughout. Marcus never looks at it directly. The player will wonder about it the entire game.

STAT EFFECTS — Scene Summary

Condition	Effect
Night visit after drug quest	TRUST_MARIE +2 before scene
Honest answers (per question)	TRUST_MARIE +1 each
Harlan question — detailed answer	CONTAINED_THREAD +1 or +2
Housing accepted	TRUST_MARIE +2, HUMANITY +5
Evasive or dishonest throughout	TRUST_MARIE net negative, housing delayed

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FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
MARIE_FORMALLY_MET	Any completed visit
MARIE_KNOWS_CURTIS	Honest answer about Curtis
MARIE_HUNGER_ACKNOWLEDGED	Honest answer about condition
HARLAN_MARIE_WARNED	Any Harlan answer except E
CONTAINED_THREAD	Incremented by Harlan answer quality
MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED	TRUST_MARIE 4+, hand taken
MARIE_HOUSING_AVAILABLE	TRUST_MARIE 4+, hand declined — available later
MARIE_HOUSING_LOCKED	TRUST_MARIE 2-3 — requires more interaction

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LEADS TO

Path	Next
Housing accepted	Marcus can move to the swamp cabin — removed from town's sight, Darnell cannot find him as easily, night cycle changes
Night visit combat	COMBAT_SYSTEM_UNLOCKED, PACK_SENSE_UNLOCKED
MARIE_KNOWS_CURTIS set	Marie will begin feeding Marcus information about the pack in future visits — leading toward the Curtis reveal
CONTAINED_THREAD active	Harlan thread accelerates — he begins to notice Marcus is asking different questions